



‘Breaking point’ for Weather Service

Staffing cuts leave forecasters struggling as storm approaches

BY HANNAH NATANSON AND BRADY DENNIS

Some National Weather Service staffers are working double shifts to keep forecasting offices open. Others are operating under a “buddy system,” in which adjacent offices help monitor severe weather in understaffed regions. Still others are jettisoning services deemed not absolutely necessary, such as making presentations to schoolchildren.

The Trump administration’s cuts to the Weather Service — where nearly 600 workers, or about 1 in every 7, have left through firings, resignations or retirements — are pushing the agency to its limits, according to interviews with current and former staffers.

The incoming head of the National Oceanic and Atmospheric Administration has promised to prioritize filling those jobs, and the White House recently granted the Weather Service an exemption from a government-wide hiring freeze. But as the Atlantic hurricane season peaks and wildfires ramp up in the West, hundreds of positions remain vacant, staff said. Forecasters are currently watching two storms, including one that could pose a threat for the eastern United States by early this week.

So far, exhausted employees have maintained weather monitoring and forecasting almost without interruption, staff said. But many are wondering how

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Imelda: Storm could bring days of heavy rain to the Southeast. **A11**

In the shadow of the war in Gaza, a dramatic expansion of settlements and escalating violence by radical settlers are among the measures transforming the occupied West Bank



HEIDI LEVINE/FOR THE WASHINGTON POST

With sweeping steps, Israel moves to remake territory

BY CLAIRE PARKER
IN MA’ALE ADUMIM, WEST BANK

Israel has taken a raft of dramatic steps this year to ensure it retains permanent control over much, if not all, of the occupied West Bank, including measures that the government had previously deferred because they were deemed too sensitive.

While much global attention has focused on Israel’s war in Gaza, Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu’s government and Israeli settlers on the ground have been remaking reality in the much larger West Bank, which is seen by many Israelis as part of the Jewish people’s historic homeland and by most of the world as the heart of a future Palestinian state.

With several major Western countries recognizing a Palestinian state last week, the Israeli

Badei Alariyeh, left, and his brother Mohammad walk through what is left of the Tulkarm refugee camp in the northern West Bank this month.

government has been weighing whether to respond by formally annexing part or all of the West Bank, a move that would be viewed widely as a violation of international law. The Israeli parliament, the Knesset, overwhelmingly approved a nonbinding motion this year to annex the territory.

The subject of annexation could arise on Monday when Netanyahu meets in Washington with President Donald Trump, who has made clear his opposition.

Netanyahu’s government and its settler allies are already laying the groundwork to eventually

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The Sunday Take: “America First” Trump swerves on world stage. **A2**

Trump to deploy troops to Portland

ESCALATES USE OF MILITARY INSIDE U.S.

As in L.A., directive likely to meet fierce opposition

BY MICHAEL BIRNBAUM, DAN LAMOTHE AND TODD C. FRANKEL

President Donald Trump said Saturday that he will send troops to Portland, Oregon, and to immigration detention facilities around the country, authorizing “Full Force, if necessary” and escalating a campaign to use the U.S. military against Americans that has little modern precedent.

Trump said in a social media post that he was directing Defense Secretary Pete Hegseth to provide troops to what he dubbed “War ravaged Portland” as well as “any of our ICE Facilities under siege from attack by Antifa, and other domestic terrorists.”

Saturday’s announcement appeared likely to set up a first test for a White House effort targeting left-wing protest groups. It came just days after Trump signed an executive order directing the nation’s full counterterrorism apparatus against domestic political opponents despite long precedent restricting such a move.

Right-wing politicians have long criticized Portland for the way it has handled racial-justice protests as well as its homeless population, tolerating encampments in the central part of the city. But Trump will again encounter the dynamic he faced when he deployed the National Guard in Los Angeles — a military activation in

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Turnaround: Zelensky says Trump has learned to distrust Putin. **A19**

Inflation fears deepen over Trump tariffs that start Oct. 1

BY ANDREW ACKERMAN AND RACHEL LERMAN

President Donald Trump’s sector-specific tariffs threaten to add fresh fuel to inflation that has remained stubbornly elevated for four years, potentially driving up costs for households at least in the short term.

The new tariffs range from 25 percent to 100 percent and target pharmaceuticals, heavy trucks, kitchen cabinets, bathroom vanities and upholstered furniture. They will take effect Wednesday.

It’s already a challenging period for consumers. Fresh data from the Commerce Department on Friday showed core inflation — the Federal Reserve’s preferred gauge of underlying price pressures — grew at a 2.9 percent annual rate in August. That was in line with expectations but up from a 2.5 percent rate in April.

“At a time when it’s looking increasingly like the U.S. is experiencing an acceleration in underlying inflation, the new tariffs announced by President Trump will only exacerbate the challenges facing households and will only make it harder for the Fed to continue cutting interest rates, as the president wishes,” said Michael Strain, director of economic policy studies at the right-leaning American Enterprise Institute.

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ALLISON JOYCE/FOR THE WASHINGTON POST

Peggy Williams prays with a volunteer from Baptists on Mission in May. Williams’s partner, Lenny Widawski, is one of the few Hurricane Helene victims whose body was never recovered.

A year later, still haunted by Helene

Gut-wrenching limbo for loved ones of local musician who vanished

BY ALLISON JOYCE AND BRADY DENNIS
IN GREEN MOUNTAIN, N.C.

“It just does me good to come out here and talk to him,” Peggy Williams said on a blue-sky morning at the brink of fall.

She had returned once again to the quiet spot by the North Toe River where, for decades, she shared a life with Lenny

Widawski, a Yancey County musician who was known for his soaring violin playing and his ever-present fedora.

Sometimes when she is here, she tells Lenny how she aches thinking about what he endured that morning last September, when Hurricane Helene turned the sleepy river into a raging torrent that carried away the small home where

they had lived.

Sometimes, she tells him she’s still angry he didn’t evacuate, despite her pleas. Williams, who was in Virginia at the time recovering from back surgery at her daughter’s house, sometimes blames herself for not being there to persuade him.

Sometimes, she reckons aloud with God, asking why the

SEE HELENE ON A24

Trump’s plans for shutdown include layoffs, deregulation

Government could be reshaped to mainly focus on defense, immigration

BY JACOB BOGAGE

Under the Trump administration’s plans for a government shutdown, the Labor Department would cut off most activities — then fire thousands of employees. National parks would close, and their staffs could face layoffs. Phone help lines at the Internal Revenue Service would go unstaffed, perhaps permanently.

National Guard deployments to major cities — D.C., Memphis and Portland — would continue. Immigration raids and deportation activities would be unaffected, though officers would work unpaid.

If Congress fails to fund the government this week, the White House is preparing for a shutdown that would reflect the purest version of President Donald Trump’s vision for the federal government, guided by White House budget director Russell Vought, an architect of the controversial Project 2025 playbook for Trump’s second term.

Federal funds expire when the fiscal year ends Tuesday night, and Congress appears deadlocked over a stopgap measure that would keep agencies online for seven weeks while long-term ne-

gotiations continue.

Under the Vought plan, the only agencies that would remain operating apace are those that received money in Trump’s One Big Beautiful Bill, the \$4.1 trillion tax and immigration package that Congress passed in July. The Defense and Homeland Security departments were the main beneficiaries.

The result, both during and potentially after a shutdown, could be a federal government dramatically reoriented to defense, immigration and law enforcement — and not much else.

“Trump is pretty clear about this and Russ Vought has been clear for his entire career,” said Newt Gingrich, the former House speaker and periodic Trump adviser. “They want a smaller government. They would like to get back to a balanced budget. ... They think that many government programs are inefficient or actually destructive, and they are prepared to aggressively pursue every opportunity that the left gives them to reshape the government.”

Traditionally in government shutdowns, employees considered vital to public safety and protecting government property continue to work unpaid, and those who are not are furloughed until Congress approves new agency funding.

But last week, Vought told agencies to prepare for mass firings if a shutdown takes hold, and even after that to “retain the

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